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Consistency is the key

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WHY WE SHOULD ALL BE MORE Selfish

Putting yourself first has more benefits to you and even the people around you than you might realise

WORDS SARAH BANKES

From a very young age, we're told to be kind, to share, to see things from other people's viewpoints, to put others first and to be polite, amongst many other life lessons. And while these are important skills to learn – equipping us with qualities that turn us into decent human beings – taking these instructions to the extreme can actually be detrimental to our own mental health and wellbeing.

As children, we probably remember our parents coming out with the following sorts of phrases (and as parents we're probably guilty of repeating these to our own children):

"Give Grandpa a kiss goodbye, go on, don't be rude..."

> "PRIORITISING YOUR NEEDS CAN BENEFIT EVERYONE INVOLVED"

"I know you don't like mushrooms, but we're guests, so eat up..."

Telling kids to do things they really don't want to do doesn't make us bad parents – nor does it make our parents wicked for doing the same – but it does send out a message that other people's feelings are more important than our own. Coupled with the idea that to be selfish is a negative trait, we're brought up to believe that to be a good person, we must at all times be selfless, altruistic and self-sacrificing, and these beliefs lead to a whole host of problems.

We can't blame our parents for everything, though. A study carried out in 2016/17 by a team from University of California, Los Angeles suggests that altruistic behaviour might actually be the default option in our brains. According to their research, an area of the prefrontal cortex can be specifically affected to make people less giving.

What's wrong with being selfless?

Excessive selflessness leads to an inability to say no. We live

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in fear of appearing rude and upsetting or offending people. As we go about our lives pleasing everybody else, if we don't burn out first, we run the risk of ultimately becoming bitter, resentful and pretty unhappy, as prioritising everybody else leaves little time to do the things we want to do.

Perhaps a distinction needs to be made between good and bad versions of selfishness. A total disregard for other people's feelings isn't always necessary when it comes to putting yourself first. However, being aware of your needs and being assertive enough to prioritise them can benefit everyone involved.

For example, a friend asks you to go shopping and, even though you already have a busy schedule and want to say no, you say yes because you don't want to let her down. What happens? You end up being late because you're squeezing it in around other things. Consequently you're stressed before you've even stepped foot inside a shop; you spend the entire trip annoyed with your friend for 'dragging you along', when actually you could have said no; and you're anxious about the next commitment in your jam-packed diary! What would the outcome have been if you'd said no? You'd feel less stressed, for sure, you'd have more time to focus on the other things you're doing that day, and you wouldn't resent your friend. And the friend? She might initially feel somewhat put out, but she wouldn't have to put up with a late, grumpy, stressed-out shopping companion! Being supposedly 'selfless' isn't always beneficial to the people you think you're helping out.

More often than not, the issue goes far deeper than wanting to please other people for *their* sake. If you'd considered the shopping situation rationally and truthfully, the friend could probably have found someone else to go with, so the real issue was perhaps not so much not wanting to let her down, but more about not wanting her to be disappointed in you. Being a people-pleaser is usually a result of seeking approval or wanting to be liked, which is often a consequence of previous life events.

Stress and anxiety are just two of the consequences of being excessively selfless. If you don't start prioritising your needs, you become ineffective at what you're trying to be, whether that's a good friend, a reliable employee or a good parent. This can then lead to low self-esteem, depression and burnout. Taking time out from the kids might feel like an indulgence but if a one-hour bubble bath is what you need to unwind and destress, your kids are going to be much happier with a relaxed parent than one who is trying to do everything for everyone, and not giving themselves a well-earned break.

Over the following pages, we talk to author and life coach Michelle Elman about how to prioritise your needs and set boundaries.



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What are parasocial relationships?

Could the relationships we share with celebrities and fictional characters help us deal with everyday challenges?

Writing | **Eleanor Noyce**

I've always been a dreamer. When I was little, I sought out comfort in fictional worlds; devouring pages and pages of Jacqueline Wilson, I developed what felt like close friendships with her characters. Tracy Beaker was my fictional best friend, her story spoke to me, and I was so compelled by her world that I forgot she didn't *actually* exist in my own.

As an adult, my favourite programmes are a nurturing presence for me, and whenever I feel down, I switch on my TV and seek comfort in what feels like a close circle of friends.

These feelings aren't just limited to me, either. Termed 'parasocial relationships', this phenomenon is defined as 'a one-sided relationship, typically between a fan and celebrity figure, whether that be the actual person or in some cases a character they play on a show or movie'.

Parasocial relationships might sound typically 2023, but the philosophy behind them predates the 21st century. The term 'parasocial interaction' was first coined by sociologists Donald Horton and Richard Wohl in 1956, referring to a psychological relationship that is experienced by an audience member towards the person or character they are encoutering, particularly on television and with celebrities. Horton and Wohl's thesis dictated that, as everyday people, we are encouraged to feel a personal connection with TV personalities. In the UK specifically, television presenters like Graham Norton and Alan Carr, or fictional

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characters like Phoebe Waller-Bridge's Fleabag are notable, modern-day examples.

As consumers, we don't know these TV personalities in real life; physically, they're little more to us than pixels on a screen. But these relationships hold real meaning to us. The set-up of a TV chat show, in particular, encourages feelings of warmth and security. Direct addresses and a living-room-type set – sofa and all – trigger a psychological feeling of connection. We feel that we're a part of their lives – that, in enjoying a chat amongst the stars with a drink, they might as well be in our own homes, sitting on our own sofas.

Evidently, there's a lot of joy to be found in parasocial relationships. Natalie Pennington, PhD, is an assistant professor in communication studies at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas. Teaching at the intersection of interpersonal communication and communication technology, she focuses on social influence and impression management. She believes that, as humans, we seek to find a connection in a variety of ways – one of those avenues is media. "We want to feel close to others. Media can sometimes create an intimacy about someone that can make you feel close, even when you're not," she explains.

And in the modern age, celebrities, famous for appearing on our screens – whether in TV shows or films – often double up on this, extending their influence via social media. "Celebrities can disclose and share information, images, and videos that are insights into their day-to-day life, which can create, for some, a feeling of closeness, even though the posts are public for anyone to see," Dr Pennington continues. "Influencers are an example of micro-celebrity, and the same thing plays out with newer social media like TikTok, where you can actually get a response from someone." In essence, social media provides another space to fill our natural, human need for connection.

> **When I feel down, I switch on my TV and seek comfort in what feels like a close circle of friends**

However, it's important – as with anything – to exercise caution. Boundaries are fundamental, as Dr Elena Touroni, a consultant psychologist and co-founder of The Chelsea Psychology Clinic, believes. "Parasocial relationships are defined by the fact that they are one-sided, which is where the problem lies," Dr Touroni states. "Healthy relationships are reciprocal – you both put energy and time into building the connection. They become dangerous when they are taken to the extreme, either coming at the cost of forming real-life connections or becoming obsessional."

But how can we tell when our own parasocial relationships are unhealthy? And how can we practise self-care when things become a little off balance?

When it comes to engaging with influencers, in particular, self-comparison can creep in. From a mental health perspective, seeing endless posts on Instagram depicting immaculately designed homes, constant social engagements, and seemingly perfect relationships, can become detrimental. Witnessing other people share their joy online can skew how we see our own lives, feeding into jealousy, and encouraging us to set unrealistically high expectations.

Centralise self-care during these moments of self-comparison. Seek joy in the little, mundane things – light a candle or read a book, spend time watering the plants, or go for a walk. For every essence of engagement in a parasocial relationship, make sure you pair that by interacting with a tangible, in-person relationship. And if you're seeking to secure more of those, why not join a book club? Or a running club? Or a knitting group? There's always a connection to be found; sometimes, you just need to look.

So, if you're looking to seek comfort in parasocial relationships, remember this: there's so much joy to experience, but place boundaries at the centre. The world is a busy, exhausting climate, and parasocial relationships – when executed properly and with caution – might just be able to provide that escapism we all need.

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